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UNITED AGAINST NEET (From top left) Students' organisations protest in Hyderabad, Jun. 18; protesters with an effigy of Union education minister Pradhan in Agartala; student Congressmen take out a torch rally in Delhi

The political ramifications of the mess are still unravelling. Union home minister Amit Shah was in a huddle with his counterparts in the education and health ministries, Dharmendra Pradhan and J.P. Nadda respectively, as well as officials from the Prime Minister's Office to decide the next course of action. The Opposition, meanwhile, has called for a nationwide protest on June 21.

For students, the rising uncertainty and loss of faith in the system has been heartbreaking. Suni Sharma from Delhi has wanted to be a doctor for as long as she can remember. So strong was her conviction that her security guard-nurse parents sold their wedding jewellery and pooled in some of their retirement savings to send her to a coaching institute in Kota so that she could crack the NEET. The 17-year-old says she studied 10-15 hours a day for two years, took some 40 mock exams to prepare for the test held on May 5 this year. But when the results came out on June 4, she was shocked. Despite scoring 550 marks out of 720, her rank was in the 100,000-plus range, nowhere near enough for her to get into a decent medical college. "I haven't been able to sleep or eat in the past two weeks," says Suni, now one of thousands of students protesting the NEET results in the capital. "Nobody will be able to understand how much hard work goes into scoring these marks...and then to not get a seat because of corruption." A score of 550 would have got Suni a rank between 40,000 and 46,000 last year, enough to get her an MBBS seat in a good college.

This year, 2.4 million students across 4,750 centres in 571 cities took the test, some 400,000 more than in 2023. An unprecedented number—67 students—scored full marks, 720, compared to just two students last year and none in 2022. Six of these perfect scorers have seat numbers in the same sequence and come from a particular exam centre in Bahadurgarh, Haryana. Incidentally, the centre, run by the wife of the local BJP youth wing chief, was plagued by issues on test day itself, including a mix-up with question papers that led to delays.

On social media, parents began sharing scorecards of students with 718 and 719 marks, an implausible total given that a correct answer is worth four marks and every wrong one docks a mark from your score. The results raised suspicions of awarding of grace marks—which 1,563 students managed (including those at the Bahadurgarh centre). Though it is still not clear how many marks were awarded, they now stand cancelled. The affected students can opt for a re-test on June 23, although experts believe the re-test is hardly likely to affect the final rankings.

The current fracas has rekindled memories of the first all-India NEET exam in 2016, where students were allowed to give a re-examination. Dr Raghav Kumar from Delhi, who completed his MBBS in 2021 from the University College of Medical Sciences in the capital, was one such aspirant that year. He says, "I opted to stick with my score in the first NEET exam instead of taking the retest. But I still remember the toll it took on my mental health...it was a gamble with my future." Kumar adds that his score of 562 (rank 1,048 in 2016) wouldn't even have got him a rank of 100,000 this year.